

Similar to Whom

A household survey of what bill-payers believe the similar-homes panel compares them with

Iben Chikere · Ingeborg Nwachukwu · Solveig Adeyemi — School of Emergent Priorities

The problem

Nearly every billed household receives a comparison panel: your usage, set beside similar homes. Reach is close to total, and is reported as such. Comprehension is not reported at all. Who do bill-payers believe those similar homes are, and does the belief match the rule that assigns them?

What we set out to test

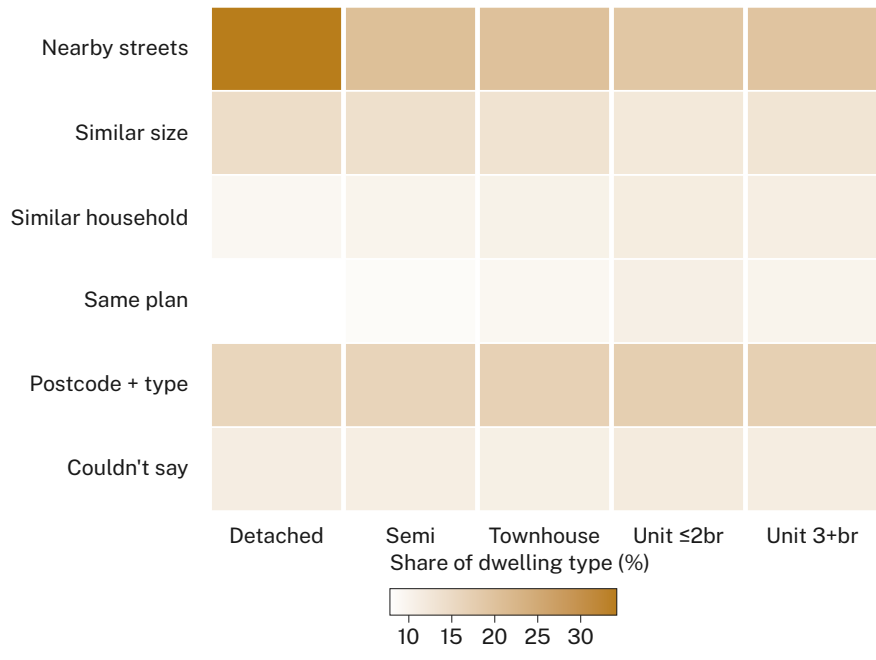
- Can a bill-payer state the basis of their own comparison group?
- Does the stated basis match the rule the retailer applies?
- Does reading the panel precede any reported action?

Materials & methods

- 2,850 addresses · stratified by dwelling type and tariff · push-to-web with postal reminder · 14 weeks
- Belief items scored against the retailer’s published peer rule (postcode band and connection type), blind to the assigned group
- Response rate 41.4%; item nonresponse reported unweighted; no incentive offered; thresholds fixed before fieldwork

What we found

Recall is high; accuracy is not. 61.8% of respondents recall the panel. Of those answering the belief item, 21.1% name the basis in use. Reported action follows for 11.6%, and the pattern holds across dwelling types.



Stated comparison basis by dwelling type (n = 704 households answering the belief item). “Homes on nearby streets” is the modal answer in every dwelling type; the basis actually applied — postcode band and connection type — is named by between 19.8% and 23.1%, and by 21.1% overall.

What it means

A panel can reach every account and be located by almost none of them. The efficiency programme’s engagement measure counts bills issued carrying the panel, so reach discharges the obligation whether or not the comparison can be found. Opacity of the peer group appears not to impede the indicator that reports the panel’s delivery. Nor does it appear to trouble the households themselves: among respondents naming a basis other than the one applied, confidence in the answer was no lower than among those naming it correctly.

Next: fielding the belief instrument alongside a legend redesign at the following billing cycle.

Selected references

1. Allcott, H. (2011). Social norms and energy conservation. *Journal of Public Economics*, 95(9–10), 1082–1095. doi:10.1016/j.jpubeco.2011.03.003
2. Schultz, P. W., Nolan, J. M., Cialdini, R. B., Goldstein, N. J., & Griskevicius, V. (2007). The constructive, destructive, and reconstructive power of social norms. *Psychological Science*, 18(5), 429–434. doi:10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01917.x
3. Attari, S. Z., DeKay, M. L., Davidson, C. I., & Bruine de Bruin, W. (2010). Public perceptions of energy consumption and savings. *PNAS*, 107(37), 16054–16059. doi:10.1073/pnas.1001509107
4. Allcott, H., & Rogers, T. (2014). The short-run and long-run effects of behavioral interventions: experimental evidence from energy conservation. *American Economic Review*, 104(10), 3003–3037. doi:10.1257/aer.104.10.3003
5. Ferraro, P. J., & Price, M. K. (2013). Using nonpecuniary strategies to influence behavior: evidence from a large-scale field experiment. *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 95(1), 64–73. doi:10.1162/REST_a_00344
6. Achterberg, L., Mensah, A., & Nwosu, J. (2026). Read, Not Answered: A Pre-Registered Cluster-Randomised Trial of Plain-Language Development Notices and Submission Rates. School of Emergent Priorities, Slo University. doi:10.5555/slop.5n7uk8

We thank the households of the surveyed distribution zones, and the retailer’s billing operations team for the peer-rule documentation.

De-identified survey responses only; no account numbers or consumption records retained. Belief items were scored blind to the assigned peer group.

Contact: iben.chikere@slop.university · Office of Research Outputs

[@slop.university](#) · [#sloPU](#)